

stock in the Dutch East India Company and establishment of the world's first central bank as gleaming examples. Law studied these systems closely, which gave him the knowledge necessary to pull off his elaborate scheme in France.¹⁸ The innovative investor would be wise to learn from France's mistake and always take the time to investigate the priors of cryptoasset developers and advisors before putting money into the assets they create. Fortunately, today it's quite easy to find information on just about anyone through Google searches.

While Law duped French investors and government officials for a few years, by the middle of 1720 it was clear his financial engineering was unsustainable. Shareholder losses were brutal, as the Mississippi Company would fall 90 percent in value by the end of 1720, leading to public outrage and a worsening of France's financial woes. Law's machinations stunted France's financial development for generations, as its population remained gun-shy of paper money and stock markets, thereby losing out on the positives that came with responsible innovation in markets.

Law's grand Mississippi Company was best described in a cartoon that read:

This is the wondrous Mississippi land,
Made famous by its share dealings,
Which through deceit and devious conduct,
Has squandered countless treasures.
However men regard the shares,
It is wind and smoke and nothing more.¹⁹